

Nagaland Post

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Media under siege

Newspapers in Manipur have stopped publication for the past six days since December 30, 2010 after A Mobi, the Editor of Sanaleibak daily who is also the vice-president of the All Manipur Working Journalists' Union as well as its spokesman, was arrested by Manipur Police on charges of collecting extorted money and handing it over to a militant outfit. Police also claimed that a large sum of money was also recovered from Mobi's possession, which was to be handed over to the militant outfit. The editors of Manipur held an emergency meeting but could not come to any decision regarding the line of action. However, the Manipur journalists' union decided to halt publication in protest till Mobi was released. If the charge against Mobi was found to be true, then it is a matter of deep concern. On the other hand, if he was found to be not guilty as charged, then the Manipur Police and the government will be held accountable for gross injustice and misuse of power. Newspapers and journalists in Manipur have found themselves literally between the devil and the deep blue sea where they would be damned if they did and damned if they didn't. Due to the constant threats and harassment meted out to journalists not only in Manipur but in other north eastern states and including Jammu and Kashmir, sometimes passive resistance and even compulsion to act on behalf of terrorist elements, can land some of them in dire straits with the security forces. Journalists in the north east find themselves under fire and this is indicated by statistics where, at least 25 journalists killed in the past two decades and over 30 arrested on charges of aiding and abetting terrorism. In states like Manipur, especially, separatists literally hold the media to ransom, forcing newspapers to publish press releases without editing forcing newspapers off stands for several days. Of the 25 journalists killed, 20 were from Assam and five from Manipur and unfortunately, not a single perpetrator has been brought to book. The pen may be mightier than the sword but in an environment of death threats and other forms of 'persuasion' journalists are often victims of both the state and non-state actors. For those in other parts of India, the plight of journalists in the north east region is less known than the news of killings, ambushes and violence. Of all north eastern states, journalists in Manipur have to function in the most difficult of circumstances as they are the focus of all militant and terrorist elements, who abuse the media for propaganda. On several occasions, journalists and editors in Manipur have been kidnapped and made to face kangaroo courts. Newspapers have also suspended publications on a number of times in protest against threats by militants and government agencies. The case of the arrest of A. Mobi is a litmus test for the due process of law to ascertain whether he is guilty or innocent. As per the law, an accused can be granted bail unless he or she is charged with a very serious offence where bail is not applicable. Perhaps the Manipur government should respond so as to put matters in perspective.

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Miserable refuge of the speechless

Language is a wonderful tool. As a medium, it enables meaningful exchange of ideas between people. Yet, its abuse also abounds. Misuse of language can range from the colourful to the obnoxious, depending on one's point of view! When it comes to misuse of language, interjections readily come to mind. Interjections are not really part of speech despite being very common in everyday speech. They express the speaker's emotion rather than thought! The category of interjections called "expletives" is what this article will deal with.

Simply put, expletives are impolite expressions. Not only is the use of expletives impolite, it is ineffective as a medium of communication. And because making ourselves understood is the primary purpose of language, and the basis of all meaningful human relationships, it is necessary to ponder over the use of expletives.

No examples are needed to know what expletives are. We are constantly exposed to a barrage of them daily, whether at the work place or elsewhere. You just have to picture rowdy college students, truck drivers, and house owners in city colonies in your minds' eye, to know what we are talking about here! Though most people are inured to them, some sensitive ears still cringe to hear them. So, if they are unpleasant to the listener and do little to enhance the reputation of the speaker, why do people continue to use them?

In some cases, bravado explains the use of expletives. Most of us seek to impress people, in one way or another. Unfortunately, the use of foul words is one way of doing just that. The chances of heads turning are higher when spoken words are in the form of expletives than otherwise. This is especially true of impressionistic youngsters. We simply don't know why they are attracted to foul language like flies to honey. One thing is clear though: peer pressure plays some role. Usually, a foul word is introduced by the leader of the group (who probably heard it on TV), and the rest simply fall in line. It catches on rapidly, because it is 'cool' to use them. Otherwise, a member of the group risks being branded 'sissy'.

Youngsters are also influenced by wrong role models—star characters in movies, especially of the gangster kind. The staple language of gangster movies is the liberal and unthinking use of expletives. Youngsters are prone to copying their styles. While the use of expletives by youngsters is harmless, and most of them grow out of them, some continue to use them for the rest of their lives.

The use of expletives uncovers the state of mind of the speaker. In that sense, language is a double-edged sword. When I call someone stupid, it reveals less about the stupidity of that person and more about the state of my mind—clearly, I am

expletives, the less educated are more prone to using them. Among the educated, the use of them would be explained by the lack of or care for civility in conversation. In a way, they would be considered "uneducated" in civility, because they are not sufficiently convinced that the use of expletives has no more purpose than to irritate the one at the receiving end and could, more often than not, lead to unintended heated exchanges.

Anger, which usually prompts the use of expletives is an indication that one has lost the argument. So, one decides to rumble or muscle through. Picture this: two people are engaged in an argument over a contested issue. Initially, each will try to proffer the best defence for his position on the issue. This will often involve heated exchange of words, which nevertheless continue to be coherent. And then if one of them makes the mistake of uttering a foul word for no apparent reason than mere exasperation, the issue gets diverted because the other will contest the unwarranted use of this foul word. The contested issue, which was the cause of the quarrel in the first place, is forgotten. And then, a fight may ensue but for a totally different reason! The point here is that the one who uses the foul word first is often the one who has run out of convincing arguments to defend his position on the issue.

Thus the use of foul words to show one's displeasure with another, or disagreement with a particular issue, is rarely effective in achieving the intended outcome. If anything, it only has the unintended consequence of diverting the issue, when the hearer takes issue with the medium and not the message.

At a time when our attention spans are getting shorter by the day, and when our patience are running dangerously thin, even a slight provocation is enough to start an argument and a fight—think of road rage. However attractive it may be, the use of foul language cannot be justified as a medium of communication.

Temperance of speech is a good virtue. If a long and extended exchange cannot be avoided, a careful picking of the words will help convey our points of views as well as cool tempers. We need to resist the temptation of taking the easy way out. The displacements of courtesy and politeness by expletives do no one good.

We don't need to be Mahatma Gandhi or Mother Teresa to learn to be careful in the choice of words. In fact, these noble souls have shown that resoluteness can be exhibited in civil, non-threatening ways. That includes the use of words. So, by arguing for civility in conversation, we are not really recommending timidity; anger or disappointments can be clearly and fully expressed without the use of expletives.

Those who continue to believe

Post-mo

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of the speechless

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The use of expletives uncovers the state of mind of the speaker. In that sense, language is a double-edged sword. When I call someone stupid, it reveals less about the stupidity of that person and more about the state of my mind—clearly, I am frustrated. Exasperated speakers, unable or unwilling to focus on the right words, will blurt out these foul words. The speaker is either intellectually impoverished (one is short of words to express the true state of one's feeling) or is arrogant. Intellectual lethargy could be another way of explaining the rampant use of expletives: one is unwilling to do the "hard work" of first formulating the right words or phrases in the mind, before allowing them to leave one's tongue!

Although the level of one's education does not explain the use of

expletives, the less educated are more prone to using them. Among the educated, the use of them would be explained by the lack of or care for civility in conversation. In a way, they would be considered "uneducated" in civility, because they are not sufficiently convinced that the use of expletives has no more purpose than to irritate the one at the receiving end and could, more often than not, lead to unintended heated exchanges.

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Those who continue to believe in the false power of expletives should be told that some of the harshest rebukes and criticisms have been rendered without the use of a single foul word. That being the case, and since the use of expletives does not help in the task making ourselves understood, it makes perfect sense to avoid their use completely. If that still doesn't convince you against their use, you better be warned that expletives are also commonly known as the "refuge of the speechless".

Peter Ki.

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Daily Devotion

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